



READY FOR TAKEOFF

The thrill of a takeoff from water was one of the high points of clipper travel. Here, a Pan American Airways Sikorsky S-40 is shown taxiing for takeoff from Miami, Florida, on its way to Port-au-Prince, Haiti.

alighting safely on the open sea, they were, understandably, considered safer for transoceanic flight than land-planes.

They could operate services to far-flung locations without the need to build and maintain a chain of airfields. And their boatlike hulls lent themselves to more spacious and luxurious accommodation than land-based airliners. This allowed the flying boats to come closer in style to the luxury ocean liners with which they competed on most routes. It was no accident that flying-boat crews dressed in nautical fashion, or that those of the most famous fleet, operated by Pan American, were dubbed “clippers” after the fastest ships of the age of sail.

As in other areas of aviation, the United States lagged behind the Europeans in the development of commercial flying-boat services in the early 1920s, even on what the Monroe Doctrine had defined as



ADVERTISING MEDIA

Pan American Airways used a variety of colorful, graphic media to advertise its new routes, including (left to right) timetable holders, posters, and baggage labels.

its home turf – Central and South America. In August to September 1925, two German Dornier Wal flying boats carried out a demonstration flight from Colombia across the Caribbean to Miami, Florida, and offered to set up an airmail service linking the US with the Caribbean islands, and coastal states with South America. Stung in its national pride, the United States refused to play ball, but the incident highlighted the need for the US to develop an overseas airmail system. The result was the Kelly Foreign Air Mail Act of 1928. As with US domestic commercial aviation, government-awarded airmail contracts were the springboard for the development of US international passenger services.

Empire building

Thanks largely to the extensive business contacts and lobbying skills of youthful entrepreneur Juan Trippe, his company Pan American, which had begun airmail services to Havana under a contract with the Cuban government in 1927, won a monopoly of US government contracts for routes throughout the Caribbean. These routes were operated by flying boat – initially Igor Sikorsky’s eight-seat S-38. In September 1929, Trippe and his wife Betty, with Pan American’s technical adviser Charles Lindbergh and his wife Anne Morrow Lindbergh, made a spectacular island-hopping flight across the Caribbean and around Central America. This publicity event